Simple Business English

Project Status Meeting: How to Report Delays and Manage Launch Risks | Business English

Situation: Tariq, a project manager at a health-snack FMCG company, meets with Fiona, the marketing director, in her office for their monthly new product launch review.
Tariq — Project Manager for New Product Introductions · **Fiona** — Marketing Director

Transcript

Fiona: Good morning, Tariq. Good to see you. Ready for our monthly project status meeting?

Tariq: Good morning, Fiona. Yes, absolutely. I prepared all the latest updates across our operational streams.

Fiona: Perfect. Our national launch is still planned for early September, correct?

Tariq: That is correct. We have ten weeks left on the master calendar before launch day.

Fiona: Excellent. Take me through the key areas so we can spot any pressing issues.

Tariq: Here is a quick overview of where things stand right now across the project.

Fiona: Good. How are you structuring the project blocks for our discussion today?

Tariq: I split everything into three clear categories: on track, behind, and at risk.

Fiona: That is a very practical structure. Let us start with the good news first.

Tariq: Regarding product development, the final recipe is fully approved and signed off.

Fiona: Wonderful news. Did the consumer taste tests meet our initial benchmark targets?

Tariq: Yes, eighty-two percent of blind testers preferred our bar over the market leader.

Fiona: That is an impressive score. What about the packaging artwork?

Tariq: The packaging design is completely finalized and already sent to the print supplier.

Fiona: Did internal legal counsel approve all nutritional claims on the front label?

Tariq: Yes, legal cleared all wording, including our twenty-gram high-protein message and sugar-free badge.

Fiona: That is a great relief. How are things looking on the manufacturing side?

Tariq: Everything is running on schedule. Our operations team has done great work preparing the lines.

Fiona: Have all the raw ingredients arrived safely at our factory warehouse?

Tariq: Yes, the bulk protein powder and natural flavors arrived without any issues.

Fiona: That is good to hear. When is our industrial pilot test scheduled to take place?

Tariq: The pilot production run is set for next Tuesday morning at nine o'clock.

Fiona: Will someone from quality assurance supervise the entire manufacturing process?

Tariq: Yes, our quality manager will be on the plant floor throughout the run.

Fiona: Great. If the pilot passes, when does commercial production begin?

Tariq: Full-scale commercial production starts on the first Monday of August.

Fiona: So operational supply chain and product formulation are completely on track.

Tariq: Exactly. We see zero operational delays in the production pipeline.

Fiona: Good. Now let us examine the yellow block. What is falling behind?

Tariq: We are currently running behind on our commercial retail listings with two major supermarket chains.

Fiona: That surprises me. I thought key accounts started talks six weeks ago.

Tariq: They started on time, but contract negotiations have stalled with two key partners.

Fiona: Which specific retail accounts are we talking about here?

Tariq: MegaMart and PrimeStore. Both accounts delayed signing their listing agreements with us.

Fiona: What is causing the delay? Did their category managers give us a specific reason?

Tariq: MegaMart postponed their annual snack category review by three full weeks due to restructuring.

Fiona: That is frustrating. Did they replace the previous category manager during this change?

Tariq: Yes, a new category buyer took over last week and restarted all evaluations.

Fiona: I understand how that delays things. What is the story with PrimeStore then?

Tariq: PrimeStore is demanding a twenty-five percent higher listing fee for eye-level placement.

Fiona: Twenty-five percent is excessive. That goes way beyond our agreed commercial launch budget.

Tariq: Our sales representative pushed back firmly, but their commercial team refuses to move.

Fiona: How much time have we lost on the retail track because of this?

Tariq: We are currently three weeks behind our target timeline for retail agreements.

Fiona: That is a serious concern. MegaMart and PrimeStore represent huge market share.

Tariq: This puts our launch date at risk. We cannot hit our target without them.

Fiona: Combined, those two chains represent nearly forty percent of our projected sales volume.

Tariq: That is why this delay threatens our total revenue target for fourth quarter.

Fiona: We definitely cannot afford to postpone our national launch until winter.

Tariq: How much time do we have left? When is our absolute cutoff date for listings?

Fiona: To lock in September distribution, we have two weeks maximum to finalize terms.

Tariq: If we miss that window, warehouse logistics cannot schedule initial store shipments.

Fiona: Then standard negotiations will not work. We need executive escalation for MegaMart immediately.

Tariq: Do you have a direct connection with their senior commercial management team?

Fiona: Yes, Arthur Cole, their new commercial director, was my colleague at my old company.

Tariq: Could you step in and speak with Arthur directly to speed up the process?

Fiona: Yes, I can contact Arthur personally and request an urgent call tomorrow.

Tariq: That would help us bypass the buyer backlog and secure our review slot.

Fiona: Please prepare a concise briefing document with product data before five today.

Tariq: I will draft that executive summary now and email it this afternoon.

Fiona: Excellent. What is our action plan for resolving the dispute with PrimeStore?

Tariq: Simon from our key account team is leading those commercial discussions right now.

Fiona: I will follow up with Simon right after lunch to review our counter-offer options together.

Tariq: Perhaps we could offer co-marketing promotions instead of paying a higher cash fee.

Fiona: That makes commercial sense. Retail buyers often accept joint promotional funding over upfront fees.

Tariq: That brings us directly to our third block: the item marked at risk.

Fiona: Right. You flagged an issue regarding our marketing launch budget.

Tariq: Exactly. Finance is reviewing third-quarter operating expenses across all departments.

Fiona: Are they trying to trim commercial budgets for upcoming product launches?

Tariq: Yes, finance proposed an across-the-board fifteen percent cut to our trade marketing budget.

Fiona: A fifteen percent cut would severely damage our in-store tasting and influencer campaigns.

Tariq: In-store sampling is our main tool to get consumers to try our new bar.

Fiona: We need to protect our promotional launch budget so the product gains immediate traction.

Tariq: Can you defend our original budget allocation during tomorrow's executive leadership meeting?

Fiona: I definitely will. I will present a strong commercial case supported by solid data.

Tariq: I can provide updated sales projection figures to strengthen your presentation slides today.

Fiona: That would be very useful. Include preliminary orders from regional retail chains too.

Tariq: We already confirmed advance orders from more than eighty independent supermarket locations nationwide.

Fiona: That is strong evidence. Finance executives respond well to confirmed customer pre-orders.

Tariq: I will incorporate those confirmed retailer numbers into your slide deck by two o'clock.

Fiona: Thank you, Tariq. Let us quickly summarize our main decisions and next steps.

Tariq: First, you will call Arthur Cole at MegaMart tomorrow to resolve the listing delay.

Fiona: Right. And I will meet with Simon today to discuss our counter-proposal for PrimeStore.

Tariq: Second, I will deliver the executive briefing sheet and financial slides this afternoon.

Fiona: Third, you will travel to the plant next Tuesday to oversee the pilot run.

Tariq: Yes, I will oversee the trial run personally and report the results.

Fiona: Are there any other potential bottlenecks or dependencies that could affect our timeline?

Tariq: No, all other components, including digital assets and logistics, are moving forward smoothly.

Fiona: Good. If we execute these corrective steps quickly, we will recover our lost time.

Tariq: I agree completely. Our team is committed to delivering the September launch.

Fiona: Thank you for your honest status reporting, Tariq. Transparency makes problem-solving much easier.

Tariq: It is my pleasure. Early visibility helps us fix issues before they grow.

Fiona: Let's touch base again in two weeks to review our progress on these action items.

Tariq: That works well for me. I will send a calendar invitation right away.

Fiona: Great. Thank you, Tariq. Have a productive rest of your day.

Tariq: Thank you, Fiona. Good luck with Arthur and the board meeting tomorrow.

Key phrases from this episode

Here is a quick overview of	introducing a brief summary of a situation — Here is a quick overview of our quarterly sales performance. — Here is a quick overview of the client's main requirements.
Everything is running on schedule.	all tasks are progressing at the expected time — Everything is running on schedule for our branch opening. — You do not need to worry, everything is running on schedule.
We are currently running behind on	delayed in completing a specific task or deliverable — We are currently running behind on supplier contracts. — The team is currently running behind on software testing.
What is causing the delay?	asking why something is taking longer than planned — What is causing the delay with customs clearance? — Can you explain what is causing the delay on this report?
This puts our launch date at risk.	this issue may cause us to miss our deadline — Packaging delays put our launch date at risk. — If they refuse, this puts our launch date at risk.
How much time do we have left?	asking about remaining available time before a deadline — How much time do we have left before store deliveries begin? — How much time do we have left to accept their offer?
Could you step in and	politely requesting a manager or colleague to intervene — Could you step in and speak with their procurement director? — Could you step in and approve this budget exception?
I will follow up with	promising to contact someone or check on progress — I will follow up with the warehouse team this afternoon. — I will follow up with our distributor tomorrow morning.
We need to protect our	emphasizing that an important resource must not be lost — We need to protect our profit margins during inflation. — We need to protect our core team during this reorganization.
Let's touch base again in	suggesting a short follow-up meeting after a specific period — Let's touch base again in a couple of days. — Let's touch base again in one week to review numbers.

Common mistakes

✗ Not: ~~We are behind the schedule by three weeks.~~
✓ Better: **We are behind schedule by three weeks.**
The business idiom is 'behind schedule', used without the definite article 'the'.

✗ Not: ~~We are late on three weeks with our retail agreements.~~
✓ Better: **We are three weeks late with our retail agreements.**
In English, state the time duration directly before 'late', not after with 'on'.

✗ Not: ~~We discussed about the trade marketing budget this morning.~~
✓ Better: **We discussed the trade marketing budget this morning.**
The verb 'discuss' takes a direct object without the preposition 'about'.

✗ Not: ~~The final result depends from the decision of retail buyers.~~
✓ Better: **The final result depends on the decision of retail buyers.**
Use 'depend on', not 'depend from' (a common native language calque).

✗ Not: ~~I will call the commercial director for negotiate better terms.~~
✓ Better: **I will call the commercial director to negotiate better terms.**
Use 'to + base verb' to express purpose, never 'for + infinitive'.

Quiz

1. What is the status of the product recipe and packaging?
A) Both are completed and fully approved.
B) The recipe needs an additional tasting round.
C) The packaging artwork was rejected by legal.

2. Why is the listing delayed with MegaMart?
A) MegaMart rejected the product taste tests.
B) Their category review was delayed by restructuring.
C) The factory failed the initial safety inspection.

3. What issue arose during negotiations with PrimeStore?
A) PrimeStore demanded a twenty-five percent higher listing fee.
B) PrimeStore refused to sell protein snacks altogether.
C) PrimeStore demanded exclusive sales rights for one year.

4. What risk does the finance department create for the launch?
A) They stopped paying external transport suppliers.
B) They proposed a fifteen percent cut to launch marketing.
C) They delayed the factory pilot run until winter.

5. How will Fiona help Tariq resolve the MegaMart delay?
A) She will call their commercial director directly.
B) She will accept all of MegaMart's penalty terms.
C) She will cancel the launch in MegaMart stores.

Answers: 1-A 2-B 3-A 4-B 5-A

Dialogue voices are AI-generated. Every episode is built on a real, anonymized case from the host's 15+ years in FMCG and key account management.